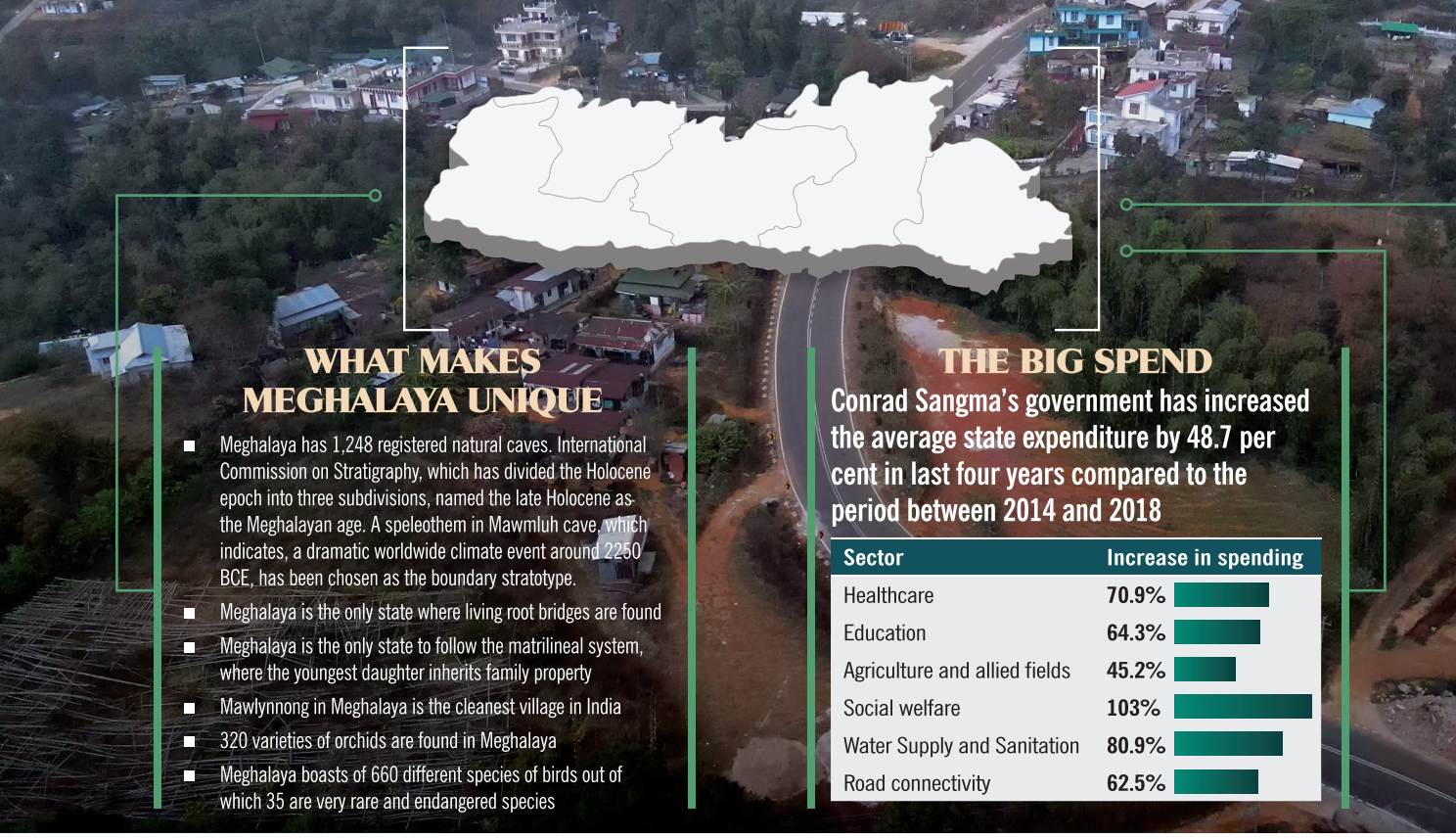


WHAT MAKES MEGHALAYA UNIQUE

- Meghalaya has 1,248 registered natural caves. International Commission on Stratigraphy, which has divided the Holocene epoch into three subdivisions, named the late Holocene as the Meghalayan age. A speleothem in Mawmluh cave, which indicates, a dramatic worldwide climate event around 2250 BCE, has been chosen as the boundary stratotype.
- Meghalaya is the only state where living root bridges are found
- Meghalaya is the only state to follow the matrilineal system, where the youngest daughter inherits family property
- Mawlynnong in Meghalaya is the cleanest village in India
- 320 varieties of orchids are found in Meghalaya
- Meghalaya boasts of 660 different species of birds out of which 35 are very rare and endangered species

THE BIG SPEND

Conrad Sangma's government has increased the average state expenditure by 48.7 per cent in last four years compared to the period between 2014 and 2018

Sector	Increase in spending
Healthcare	70.9%
Education	64.3%
Agriculture and allied fields	45.2%
Social welfare	103%
Water Supply and Sanitation	80.9%
Road connectivity	62.5%

The administration, from top to bottom, was given categorical objectives—ensuring livelihoods for all, building infrastructure for growth, nurturing the youth and children, empowering women, providing good governance and welfare to all, and making Meghalaya one of the top 10 states in the country in next 10 years, in in GSDP per capita and SDG ranking. "Our government has laid the foundation and Meghalaya will become one of the top 10 states in the country in the next 10 years. We will do it. We need to realise the importance as a society to move positively in the direction that we have set," says Chief Minister Conrad Sangma.

The management graduate chief minister understood the importance of administrative reforms to achieve this lofty goal. Several departments were restructured to create synergy and ensure faster delivery. He emphasized on the mutual co-operation among different departments and the society for achieving bigger objectives. "It is important that departments and people converge and combine efforts to achieve the larger vision and goal," says the chief minister.

Highlighting the roadmap for the development of the state, the chief minister paid attention to administrative expansion, especially at the block level to help ease of doing business for the common man as 70 per cent of the services that the people need is through blocks. And the chief minister did not lose sight of the hard realities. There were still villages in Meghalaya where people had to travel more than two hours just to get their old age pension or to see the MGNREGA wages. The Conrad Sangma government took steps to improve this and create more administrative units at the grassroots level. Meghalaya has now improved its performance in various schemes, bringing Meghalaya from bottom to the top.

But more importantly, what Chief Minister Sangma wanted to achieve first was taking the fruits of development to every citizen of Meghalaya. The government has been working with commitment and confidence to ensure holistic and overall growth and progress in the state. The constant endeavour is not to leave behind any region in Meghalaya's journey towards progress and prosperity. "We cannot bring changes only by developing Shillong and Tura or town areas. Development should reach the remotest areas of the state. Even the people living in the remotest areas should have access to development that they deserve," says Conrad Sangma. As 80 per cent of the population reside in rural areas, the focus is more on the taking modern amenities and infrastructure to the villages. "Development has no meaning if it is not inclusive. Every citizen must be equal stakeholder in the process. In these last four years, we haven't left any section of the society behind. We are committed to include all the sections of the society and facilitate in their physical and social well-being," adds the chief minister.

It was a highly challenging journey, made even more difficult by Covid pandemic, which hit the state, along with the rest of the world, in 2020. The flight to growth, prosperity and social justice came to a grinding halt as mankind began fighting back the onslaught of an invisible virus. But there was no scope to pause for long.

Meghalaya followed a unique collaborative approach in dealing with the Covid challenges, by involving the community leaders, localities, religious institutions and above all the people of the state. While the state government upgraded the infrastructure of several health facilities on war-footing, it fundamentally introduced a new model—"Behaviour Change Model for living with COVID-19"—which involves treating every resident as an asymptomatic carrier of the virus. An order was issued to treat everyone in the state as "Category 'A' patients unless they are tested on a continuous basis. The 'Category A' patient had to follow three non-negotiable practices: compulsory mask-wearing, hand hygiene and social distancing. This practice involved vigilant de-centralized monitoring by the communities. Hence, people in the state could perform their usual livelihood activities. In the pandemic year alone, Meghalaya witnessed a never seen before growth in rural roads—2.2 km roads were constructed every day.

Even as the collective battle against the lethal virus continues, Meghalaya and the world has limped back to what can be called "normal". The "engine" for development has been re-ignited and the programmes and policies to resolve the various unmet needs of the different sections of the society have been put on fast track.

As the state has completed 50 years of statehood, the momentous occasion also provides an opportunity to showcase the unprecedented socio-economic development Meghalaya witnessed during the tenure of Chief Minister Conrad Sangma. And the backbone of this developmental journey has been good governance. "We are building a brand Meghalaya on which every citizen can capitalize and benefit. Together, we have taken significant strides in the development of the state through collaborative governance, decisive leadership, and determination," says Conrad Sangma.

And the results are showing. The government has provided rural employment to a greater number of people and financially empowered more women than ever before. It has provided improved and innovative health care, ensured safe and uninterrupted supply of water and electricity, and implemented specific programmes for prosperity and welfare of the farmers.

The youth in Meghalaya now have more facilities and opportunities. Conrad Sangma government has rolled out the YESS (Youth Engagement through empowered Youth organizations) programme to empower young people to change their communities. YESS Meghalaya provides